opposed by everybody,' recalls Lehar Singh. 'Otherwise that ground was for playing. It was used for namaaz only on Ramadan and Id, rest of the time for cricket.'[49] The dispute assumed political overtones when the Congress state government gave the AeI permission to construct this building. Many local residents argued that they would no longer be able to play cricket there and a group opposed to the construction (B.S. Shettar and 105 others) went to court.

The government's order was overturned by a local munsif court, which held it 'illegal and ineffectual' and upheld the 'right of people to use the Idgah maidan for jatras and other activities'.[50] The court also ordered the removal of the structure built by the AeI. Both the additional sessions judge and the Karnataka High Court in July 1992 agreed with the munsif order and directed the Hubli-Dharwad Municipal Corporation (HDMC) to demolish the building. The AeI then appealed to the Supreme Court, which stayed the demolition of the building at the time, while keeping the main appeal pending.[51] The BJP's local leadership organised around this complex local dispute and that 'small piece of land became synonymous with Hindu mobilisation in the state'.[52]

In the north, the then BJP president Murali Manohar Joshi had gone on an Ekta Yatra to Kashmir to hoist the national flag in Srinagar. Coinciding with this, in the south, the local BJP leadership decided to launch a movement to hoist the national flag at Hubli's Idgah Maidan. On Republic Day 1992, a group of BJP, RSS and VHP leaders planned to hoist the tricolour at the Idgah Maidan in sync with Joshi's flag-hoisting at Srinagar's Lal Chowk. When the AeI refused to allow the flag-hoisting, arguing that this was private property, Hubli erupted. The Congress state government under S. Bangarappa backed the AeI. It denied the protesters permission for flag-hoisting, but despite prohibitory orders, a group of young men managed to enter the ground and hoist the tricolour. As *The Times of India* reported later, 'the matter would have ended there, but for the panicky reaction of the police, who removed the flag. This made the issue contentious.'[53]